EMUNOT VEDEOT: SAADIAH GAON'S BOOK OF BELIEFS AND OPINIONS

When May We Read the Torah as Allegory?

Given Monday 12 May 2025 · Emunot VeDeot, Essay 7:2-3

Sefer: Emunot VeDeot (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) by Rav Saadia Gaon

Essay/Chapters: Essay 7 (The Resurrection of the Dead), Chapters 2 and 3

Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Monday series on Emunot VeDeot, Monday 12 May 2025, on Zoom

These notes are based on a transcript of the recording.

Recap: Two Resurrections and Four Avenues

Essays 7, 8 and 9 are all about the end of times: *techiyat hametim*, Mashiach, and Olam HaBa (what reward and punishment are). Tonight continues the first part of Saadia's eschatology.

- **Two resurrections.** One ushers in the world to come, for anyone, Jew or non-Jew, who has a *chelek le'olam haba*; that is discussed in Essay 9. The other is **be'et hage'ulah**, at the time of redemption: in this world, unique to the tzaddikim of Israel. This essay focuses more on that one.
- **Four avenues of challenge**, whichever resurrection we mean: is it impossible by **nature**, by **logic**, by **Scripture**, or by the **tradition** of the Chachamim?

Chapter 1, the challenge from nature

1. **"We've never seen it."** Do you doubt all the miracles of the Torah? Just as Hashem did those, He can do this.
2. **"Not enough matter."** Even Hashem cannot do the impossible, like making 10 smaller than 5. But Saadia showed that Hashem created each human from distinct matter, so each can be resurrected individually. (Whether his figures for the quantity of matter are scientifically true today "is not the point.")
3. **"Matter that passes through many forms."** A man is eaten by a lion, the lion is fed to a fish, a man eats the fish, and that man is burned to ash. Saadia's point: only Hashem can create **יש מאין**, something from nothing; humans can only make **יש מיש**. In the same way, humans can break something down into something else, however fine, but **no one can destroy something into nothing**.

After the Holocaust; cremation; tattoos

This question was asked after the Holocaust about those who were gassed and burned, *Hashem yikom damam*: how will they be resurrected? The answer given was the same: the matter has been broken down very finely, "but it's there... Humans cannot destroy into nothing."

Cremation. We instinctively recoil from it, and "obviously it's forbidden." But pinpointing exactly what the prohibition is "is a whole shiur in its own right." One argument, put forward by the **Munkatcher Rebbe** about a hundred years ago, was that cremating yourself denies *techiyat hametim*. "Based on everything which we've learned in Saadia and other Rishonim, that argument does not stand." It is forbidden for other reasons, but not because it prevents resurrection.

Tattoos. "If you have a tattoo on your body, you won't be resurrected." The Rabbi suggested some Jewish mother made it up to stop her son getting one. A tattoo that violates the Torah's definition is a negative prohibition punishable by lashes, like any other, and has nothing to do with *techiyat hametim*.

Chapter 2: The Challenge from Logic

"A really important" chapter: when do we have the right to interpret the Torah metaphorically?

Three logical challenges

Saadia now turns to the avenue of reason, and finds **ואחר כן חקרתי במוצא השלישי שהוא מחשבה בשכל.** three possible logical objections:

1. **It is impossible**, and therefore illogical. Already answered in Chapter 1: there is enough matter.
2. **The One who can do it never promised it**; that is, the resurrection verses should be reinterpreted. This is the heart of the chapter.
3. **The consequences are illogical**, which would make the principle itself illogical. Saadia will deal with the ramifications of resurrection in Chapter 8.

On the second: there are many verses that promise resurrection. Even if one could find other ways to interpret them, "after analysis I don't believe there's any reason" to do so. **כי כל אשר בספרי הנביאים הוא כאשר נראה משמעו**: everything in the books of the prophets means what its words plainly indicate.

The presumption of literalism

So when you study Tanach, your starting, *prima facie* presumption is that it is **literal**. Contrast **Midrash**, where, as the Rambam writes, the presumption is that it is not literal.

Nowadays "it's very popular" to allegorise parts of the Torah. The Rabbi said he did not like to repeat nonsense, but there are even some rabbis who say that Avraham, Yitzchak and Yaakov were not real historical figures but symbols, that Avraham and Sarah are **חומר וצורה**, matter and form. And Saadia himself has already allegorised: throughout Essay 2, all the references to Hashem's hands, legs and eyes are metaphor. "Eyes" means Hashem watches over; "I stretch My hand over Egypt" means He punishes. "Great, lovely. But then where are the limits to that?"

Only four cases

Only in four cases may the Torah be read non-literally:

1. When it contradicts the senses. Adam called his wife **חוה** because **היא היתה אם כל חי**, the mother of all living. Is she the mother of all life? There are many animals not born of Chavah. So it must mean the mother of all **human** life.

2. When it contradicts reason. כי ה' אלקיך אש אכלה: Hashem is a consuming fire. It goes against all logic to say the Omnipresent is fire. So the verse is missing a letter of comparison, the *kaf*: He is **like** a consuming fire. His punishment, if you anger Him, spreads quickly as fire devours, as it says elsewhere, **כי אש קדחה באפי**.

3. When two verses contradict. Malachi says of tzedakah, **ובחנוני נא בזאת**, test Me with this. But the Torah says **לא תנסו את ה' אלקיכם**, do not test Hashem. So there must be two kinds of testing:

- **Testing whether Hashem is able** to do something: forbidden. In the desert, Israel asked **היוכל אל לערך שלחן במדבר**, can God set a table in the wilderness?

- **Testing whether I am worthy**, having acknowledged that He can: permitted. **Gideon** said, if You will save Israel through me, **אנסה נא רק הפעם בגזה**, let me test just once with the fleece, asking for dew on the fleece and then on the ground. Gideon was apprehensive about going into battle. He knew Hashem could do it; the question was whether He would do it for him, whether he was on a sufficient spiritual level. If so, he would feel confident to lead. "And we have the right to understand that because of the contradiction."

4. When it contradicts the tradition. The Torah says **ארבעים יכנו לא יסיף**, forty lashes, but we know from the whole tractate of Makkot that it is **39**. The Torah is rounding off.

Where else does the Torah round off? "We read this every year, I don't think people realise this." After the sin of the spies, who toured the land for forty days, Hashem decreed **יום לשנה**, a year for each day, forty years in the desert. But the spies were sent more than a year after the Exodus, so from the decree it was only 39 years. **והשנה הראשונה כבר עברה בלא עונש**: the first year had already passed without that punishment. So "forty" is rounded.

When one of these four applies, we look for another usage of the words until the verse fits. But without one of them, **we may not take the resurrection verses out of their plain sense**. We should leave them as they are, for the One who promised them is able and knows.

Further examples

- **Reason:** the **Rambam** reinterpreted all the Torah's appearances of **angels** as happening in dreams or prophetic visions, because angels are non-corporeal and cannot literally come down to humans. Similarly **Bilam's donkey**: the whole story in Parashat Balak, the three beatings and the donkey answering back, happened in a vision, in Bilam's mind. "Because the Rambam must feel that this is something which is illogical for donkeys to speak. Yes, Hashem does miracles, but... this is too much."
- **Tradition: לא תבשל גדי בחלב אמו**, if we stopped there, would only forbid a kid in its own mother's milk. But the oral tradition says the Torah forbids any kosher meat with any milk. So "kid in its mother's milk" is an example, not a limit.

Saadia's "reductio" in Chapter 5

The Rabbi previewed Chapter 5, where Saadia presses the point: if you allegorise resurrection, I will allegorise the whole Torah. "Do not eat *chametz* on Pesach" could mean "do not commit adultery," and "do not light a fire on Shabbat" could mean "do not go to war on Shabbat," and he brings verses to support each. "If you're going to start doing this, there's no end... There'll be no mitzvot left in the Torah."

Who decides what contradicts the senses or reason?

"Lovely. But the problem is these four things, some of them are very specified." We know what our tradition says; we can see a contradiction between verses. "But then observation of our senses or logic, who defines what our senses are?"

The age of the universe. Most of the scientific world says the universe is billions of years old. A simple reading of the Torah seems to say about 6,000. Do we have the right to reinterpret? The Rabbi asked the class which category it would fall under. Not tradition, and not a contradiction between verses. Not logic, he argued: "it's not illogical to say the world is 6,000 years old. It's only illogical to say that when you have the data." And data, the tree rings and the bones, is observed with the senses. So it would be the senses. Then the counter-argument: who says to rely on the scientific data? "You can question everything... You can see something with your eyes and you can say, am I really seeing it?" Some will say, "I haven't seen the world to be billions of years old, therefore... I don't have the right to reinterpret." "I don't have an answer to that. I'm just raising the question."

Logic is just as open. The Rambam says it is illogical for donkeys to speak; others say if Hashem split the sea He can make a donkey talk. **אין לדבר סוף.** Even Hashem's corporeality: "I'm not talking about *amei ha'aretz*... I'm talking about great *chachamim* in Germany" who believed Hashem had a body, because the Torah says so, and who did not think it went against logic. "Who defines what logic is? ... This is why there is so much argument about these things."

Avraham and Sarah as symbols: an old debate

This is not a modern argument. The **Rashba** already mentioned such people around him, and blamed the Rambam's books. There were two famous bans on the Rambam's books, the second in the time of the Rashba, and **Abba Mari**, who pushed for it, argued that people were using the Rambam to allegorise everything. The classic example, 800 years ago: Avraham and Sarah were not real people but symbols of *chomer* and *tzurah*.

By Saadia's four categories, may a rabbi say so in shul? A participant said no, because it is written in the Torah and the Torah is true. But does it fit one of the four? Only, the Rabbi said, by a "quite weak" argument that it contradicts the senses because we lack historical evidence.

The Rambam's Refinement: Moreh Nevuchim 2:25

The Rambam "doesn't argue with Saadia, but he refines it, I would say." He discusses the creation of the world. **Aristotle**, whom the Rambam highly revered, believed in God but held that the universe, like God, is eternal, with no act of creation. Can we reinterpret **בראשית ברא אלקים** to fit him?

The Rambam, as the Rabbi translated: the reason I rejected the eternity of the world is **not** that the Torah says otherwise. **The verses that indicate creation are no more numerous than the verses about Hashem having a body**, and we reinterpret those. In fact, it would have been easier to reinterpret the first chapters of Bereishit than all the verses throughout Tanach about God's body. So why not? Two reasons:

1. **Proof.** That Hashem has no body has been **proven**, rationally: it is impossible for the God we believe in to have a body, so we are forced to reinterpret. The eternity of the world has **not** been proven; Aristotle had arguments, but no conclusive proof. "I only reinterpret Torah when I have a clear proof."
2. **Foundations.** Believing Hashem has no body **does not destroy any foundation of the Torah** or contradict any prophet; the verse about His "hand" is no real contradiction. But Aristotle's eternal, unchanging world **היא הורסת את התורה מעיקרה**, destroys the Torah from its root, since it denies all miracles and all our hopes for the future.

So for the Rambam, two conditions: there must be a **need** (a proof forcing reinterpretation), and even then you may not reinterpret if it would **destroy a fundamental** of the faith. Even so, "it's still open for interpretation": the incorporeality of God is proven "in the Rambam's mind."

Applying it

- **Avraham, Yitzchak and Yaakov as symbols?** "A resounding no." You are not forced to it, since there is no evidence against them, "some people say there's evidence. Okay, but doesn't force you." And it would destroy the whole Torah.
- **Har Sinai,** where Hashem revealed Himself to 600,000 men? Lack of evidence in neighbouring civilisations "isn't a proof of evidence against," so it is not forced, and reinterpreting it would destroy the Torah.
- **Bilam's donkey?** Reinterpreting does not destroy the Torah, since a talking donkey is not a principle. Must you? According to the Rambam, yes. Others say Hashem can do that.

The overarching principles agreed by all: you may not reinterpret where it would undermine our fundamentals (the Rambam), and, from Saadia, only where the text conflicts with the senses, with reason, with another verse, or with tradition.

Chapter 3: The Challenge from Scripture

Now the third avenue: are there verses that seem to deny resurrection? Saadia brings two groups.

Group 1: "He does not return"

ויזכר כי בשר המה רוח הולך ולא ישוב (Tehillim 78): He remembers that they are flesh, a passing wind that does not return.

אנוש כחציר ימיו כציץ השדה כן יציץ. כי רוח עברה בו ואיננו (Tehillim 103): man's days are like grass; the wind passes over him and he is gone.

כלה ענן וילך... לא ישוב עוד לביתו (Iyov): like a cloud that passes, he will not return to his home.

ואיש שכב ולא יקום (Iyov): a man lies down and does not rise.

The Rabbi asked the class for the one simple answer to all of them. Saadia: these verses **underscore how mortal a human is**. Once in the grave, **you cannot choose to get up of your own accord**. None of them says that Hashem will not resurrect.

- When **people** say them, as David does in Tehillim, they are **pleas for mercy**: look how mortal we are, have mercy on us.
- When **Hashem** says them, they describe His compassion for creatures who have no power of their own.
- And the more Scripture stresses that man cannot rise by himself, the more it **magnifies Hashem's greatness**, since only He can raise him, just as at Har Sinai: has anyone ever heard the voice of God and lived?

Group 2: Kohelet 9

"Before we see Saadia inside," the Rabbi read the verses in Kohelet 9:

כי מי אשר יבחר אל כל החיים יש בטחון כי לכלב חי הוא טוב מן האריה המת. כי החיים יודעים שימתו והמתים אינם יודעים מאומה ואין עוד להם שכר כי נשכח זכרם. גם אהבתם גם שנאתם גם קנאתם כבר אבדה וחלק אין להם עוד לעולם בכל אשר נעשה תחת השמש.

Whoever is still among the living has hope: a live dog is better than a dead lion. The living know they will die; the dead know nothing, they have no more reward, their memory is forgotten. Their love, their hatred, their jealousy are already lost, and they have no more portion in anything done under the sun. "Pretty clear these verses seem to be saying that once you die, you die."

Saadia admits: **זאת הספיקה חזקה**, this is a strong difficulty. His answer comes from **the verse before**: **לב בני אדם מלא רע והוללות בלבבם בחייהם ואחריו אל המתים**, the hearts of men are full of evil and madness while they live, and after that, to the dead. So, says Saadia, these are **not Shlomo's own words**. They are Shlomo reporting **the words of the fools** whose hearts are full of madness: what's the point of life, once you die there's nothing.

The parallel: Pharaoh's **מי ה' אשר אשמע בקלו**, "who is Hashem that I should listen to Him?" Taken alone, the verse seems to say there is no God. But it is the Torah reporting what Pharaoh said. So too here. And since Shlomo calls these views madness, whoever holds them is unworthy of a portion in the world to come, as it says, **לא יגרך רע**, evil shall not dwell with You. **המקום יצילנו מכל צרה ומכל אולת**: may Hashem save us from all trouble and all folly.

Other commentators. The **Ibn Ezra** says exactly like Saadia: these are the words of the wicked. The **Metzudat David** reads them as Shlomo's own words, with a different message: while you are alive, **יש בטחון**, you still have hope, because you can still do teshuvah. That is why a live dog is better than a dead lion. The living know they will die, and so can still repent; once dead, you no longer have the ability to change. "Use your life well."

Summary

1. **Nothing can be destroyed into nothing**, so even those burned in the Holocaust will rise. Cremation is forbidden, but not because it prevents resurrection; and tattoos have nothing to do with it.
2. **Three logical challenges**: impossibility (answered in Chapter 1), reinterpretation (this chapter), and absurd consequences (Chapter 8).
3. **Tanach is presumed literal** (Midrash the opposite). It may be read otherwise **only** when it contradicts the senses (*em kol chai*), reason (*esh ochlah*), another verse (testing Hashem: Gideon's fleece), or tradition (forty lashes as 39, like 39 years "rounded" to 40).
4. **But who defines the senses and reason?** The age of the universe, Bilam's donkey and God's corporeality show how open those two categories are.
5. **The Rambam's refinement** (Moreh 2:25): reinterpret only when forced by proof, and never where it would destroy a fundamental. Hence God's body is reinterpreted, but creation is not; nor Avraham and Sarah, nor Har Sinai.
6. **Verses that seem to deny resurrection** only stress that man cannot rise by himself. **Kohelet 9** reports the words of fools (Saadia, Ibn Ezra), or urges teshuvah while alive (Metzudat David).

Coming Up

Chapter 4: the verses throughout Tanach that show *techiyat hametim* will happen. **Chapter 5:** Saadia's demonstration that if those verses are allegory, the whole Torah can be allegorised.

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